The Bad Seed

by Maxwell Anderson

INTRODUCTION

Radio: *"I interrupt this broadcast to- I have been asked to announce that one of the children on the annual outgoing of the Fern Grammar School was accidentally drowned in the bay this afternoon. The name of the victim is being withheld until the parents are first notified. More news of the tragic affair is expected momentarily." "He appears to have fallen into the water from an abandoned wharf on the Fern property. How the little boy got on the wharf, for all the children had been forbidden to play near or on it, but his body was found off the end of the landing, wedged among the pilings. The guards who brought up the body applied artificial respiration without result. There were bruises on the forehead and hands, but it is assumed these were caused by the body washing against the pilings. And now back to the national news."*

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Rhoda: Mother, you know we didn't really have our lunch because Claude Daigle was drowned.

Christine: I know. It was on the radio.

Rhoda: He was drowned, so then they were all rushing and calling and hurrying to see if they could make him alive again, but they couldn't, so then they said the picnic was over and we had to go home.

Christine: I'm glad you're home!

Rhoda: So could I have a peanut-butter sandwich and milk?

Christine: Did you see him dear?

Rhoda: Yes, of course. Then they put a blanket over him.

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Christine: Did you see him taken from the water?

Rhoda: Yes, they laid him out on the lawn and worked and worked. But it didn't help.

Christine: I want you to get those pictures right out of your mind. I don't want you to be frightened or bothered at all. These things happen sometimes and when they do we simply accept them.

Rhoda: I thought it was exciting. Could I have my peanut-butter sandwich?

Christine: Darling, you're controlling yourself very well, but just the same it was an unfortunate thing to see and remember. I understand how you feel, my darling.

Rhoda: I don't know what you're talking about. I don't feel anyway at all. [*Rhoda, seeing she has displeased her mother, rises and throws her arms around her waist, then takes her mother's hand and kisses it.]*

Christine: Have you been naughty?

Rhoda: Why, no mother. What will you give me if I give you a basket of kisses?

Christine: I'll give you a basket of hugs.

Rhoda: I want to go out and skate on the asphalt.

Christine: Then you should go dear.

Rhoda exits through the kitchen, just as Miss Fern, an administrator from Rhoda's school rings the bell

Miss Fern: May I come in, Mrs. Penmark?

Christine: Yes, of course, Miss Fern. I meant to come and see you.

Miss Fern: We're in such distress, all of us at school, and we've suffered such a blow, losing one of the children that way, I'm sure you'll excuse us for going over and over things!

Christine: I think everybody has been puzzled and worried and saddened.

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Miss Fern: I don't think I've ever known any happening to puzzle so many people in so many ways. And I can help so few of them. I've just come from seeing Mrs. Daigle. Of course, our first thought was of her. The rest of us are toughed only lightly by this tragedy. She will have to live with it the rest of her days.

Christine: I know.

Miss Fern: I have seen her several times, and each time she has asked me to find out from you if you had any possible clue to where the penmanship medal might be.

Christine: Was it lost?

Miss Fern: Yes, it wasn't found with the body and has completely disappeared.

Christine: I didn't know of this.

Rhoda: Good morning, Miss Fern.

Miss Fern: Good morning, Rhoda.

Rhoda: Mother, could I sit under the arbor for a whole and read my book?

Christine: Of course, Rhoda.

Rhoda: It's shady there, and I can see your window, and you can watch me from the window, and I like to be where you can see me. Good Bye Miss Fern.

Miss Fern: It did occur to me that- that Rhoda might have told you a detail or two which she hadn't remembered when she talked with me. You see, she was the last to see the little Daigle boy alive-

Christine: Are you sure of that? I hadn't realized—

Miss Fern: About an hour after we arrived at the estate one of our older pupils came on Rhoda and Claude at the far end of the grounds. The boy was upset and crying, and Rhoda was standing in from of him, blocking his path. The older girl was among the trees, and neither child saw her. She was just about to intervene when Rhoda shoved the boy and snatched at his medal, but he broke away and ran down the beach in the direction of the wharf where he

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was later found. Rhoda followed him, not running, just walking along, taking her time, the older girl said.

Christine: Has it occurred to you that the older girl might not have been telling the truth?

Miss Fern: That isn't at all likely. She was on of the monitors we appointed to keep an eye on the younger children. She's fifteen and has been with us since kindergarten days. No, Mrs. Penmark, she was telling precisely what she saw. We know her well.

Christine: And this was the last time Claude was seen?

Miss Fern: Yes. A little later—it might have been about noon—one of the guards saw Rhoda coming off the wharf. He shouted a warning, but by then she was on the beach again and he decided to forget the matter. The guard didn't identify the girl by name, but she was wearing a red dress, he said, and Rhoda was the only girl who wore a dress that day. At one o'clock the lunch bell rang and Claude was missing when the roll was called. You know the rest, I think.

Christine: Yes. But this is very serious—if Rhoda was on the wharf----

Miss Fern: Not serious, really, when you've seen as much of how children behave as I have. Children conceal things from adults. Suppose Rhoda did follow the Daigle child onto the wharf-so many things could have happened quite innocently. He may have concealed himself in the old boathouse and then, when discovered, may have backed away from Rhoda and fallen in the water.

Christine: Yes, that could have happened.

Miss Fern: Now, Claude, although he looked frail, was an excellent swimmer—and, of course Rhoda knew that. Once he was in the water she would have expected him to swim ashore. How could she know that the treacherous pilings were at the exact spot where he fell?

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Christine: No, she couldn't possibly…

Miss Fern: Perhaps the thought in Rhoda's mind when he fell in the water was that he's ruin his new suit and she'd get scolding for causing it. When he didn't swim ashore at once she may have thought, with the logic of childhood, that he'd hidden under the wharf to frighten her—or to escape her. Later on, when it was too late to do anything, she was afraid to admit what had happened.

Christine: Them you think Rhoda knows something she isn't admitting?

Miss Fern: Yes. I think that, like many a frightened soldier, she deserted under fire. This is not a serious charge. Few of us are courageous when tested.

Christine: She has lied, though.

Miss Fern: Is there any adult who hasn't lied? Smooth the lines from your brow, my dear. You're so much prettier when smiling.

Christine: I shall question Rhoda.

Miss Fern: I wish you would, though I doubt that you'll learn more than you know.

Christine: Miss Fern, there's something I want to ask you. There was a floral tribute at Claude's funeral sent by the children of the Fern School. I suppose the children shared in the expense—but I haven't been asked to pay any part of it.

Miss Fern: No, my dear. We thought perhaps you'd want to send flowers individually.

Christine: But why should we have sent flowers individually? Rhoda wasn't friendly with the boy, and my husband and I had never met the Daigles.

Miss Fern: I don't know, my dear, I really---there are three of us, you know, and in the hurry of making decisions

Christine: You make excuses for Rhoda—and then you admit that you didn't ask me to help pay for the flowers—and the reasons you give for not asking are obviously suspicious. Does this mean that in your mind, and the minds of your

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sisters, there is some connection between Claude's death and Rhoda's presents on the wharf?

Miss Fern: I refuse to believe there is any connection.

Christine: And yet you have acted as if there were.

Miss Fern: Perhaps we have.

Christine: This is a terrible tragedy for Mrs. Daigle, as you say. She has lost her only child. But if there were any shadow over Rhoda—from what has happened—I shall have to live under it—and my husband too. As for Rhoda—she would not be happy in your school next year—and you have already decided not to invite her back.

Miss Fern: We have made that decision.

Christine: But you can't tell me why?

Miss Fern: I think her behavior in the matter of the medal would be sufficient explanation. She has no sense of fair play. She's a poor loser. She doesn't play the game.

Christine: I'll talk to Rhoda. I know there isn't anything that will help. But I'll do what I can.

[Miss Fern leaves and Christine opens Rhoda's table drawer and finds the locket in the chocolate box. Lifts the edge of the drawer's felt lining and sees the Penmanship Medal]

Rhoda: Did you want me to come in, Mother?

Christine: So you had the medal, after all. Claude Daigle's medal.

Rhoda: Where did you find it?

Christine: How did the penmanship medal happen to be hidden under the lining of the drawer of your table, Rhoda? Now I want you to tell me the truth. [*Rhoda*

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takes off one of her shoes and examines it. Then smiles a little in a fashion she had always found charming]

Rhoda: When we move into our new house can we have an arbor, Mother? Can we, Mother? It's so shady, and pretty, and I love sitting in it!

Christine: Answer my question. And remember I'm not as innocent about what went on at the picnic as you think. Miss Fern has told me a great deal. So please don't bother to make up any story for my benefit. How did Claude Daigle's medal get in your drawer? It certainly didn't get there by itself. I'm waiting for your answer.

Rhoda: I don't know how the medal got there, Mother. How could I?

Christine: You know. You know very well how it got there. Did you go on the wharf at any time during the picnic? At any time?

Rhoda: Yes Mother. I went there once.

Christine: Was it before or after you were bothering Claude?

Rhoda: I wasn't bothering Claude, Mother. What makes you think that?

Christine: Why did you go on the wharf?

Rhoda: It was real early. When we first go there.

Christine: Why did you go on the wharf? You knew it was forbidden.

Rhoda: One of the big boys said there were little oysters that grew on the pilings. I wanted to see if they did.

Christine: One of the guards said he saw you coming off the wharf. And he says it was just a little before lunch time.

Rhoda: I don't know why he says that. He's wrong, and I told Miss Fern he was wrong. He hollered at me to come off the wharf and I did. Went back to the lawn and that's where I saw Claude. But I wasn't bothering him.

Christine: What did you say to Claude?

Rhoda: I said—if I didn't win the medal, I was glad he did.

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Christine: Please, please, Rhoda. I know you're an adroit liar. But I must have the truth.

Rhoda: But it's all true, Mother. Every word.

Christine: One of the monitors saw you try to snatch the medal off Claude's shirt. Is that all true? Every word?

Rhoda: Oh, that big girl was Mary Beth Musgrove. She told everybody she saw me. You see, Claude and I wee just playing a game we made up. He said if I could catch him in ten minutes and touch the medal with my hand—it was like prisoners base—he'd let me wear the medal for an hour. How can Mary Beth say I took the medal? I didn't.

Christine: She didn't say you took the medal she said you grabbed at it. And that Claude ran away down the beach. Did you have the medal even then?

Rhoda: No mommy. Not then.

Christine: Rhoda, how did you get the medal.

Rhoda: Oh, I got it later on.

Christine: How?

Rhoda: Claude went back on his promise and I followed him up the beach. Then he stopped and said I could wear the medal all day if I gave him fifty cents.

Christine: Rhoda, stop that! Is that the truth?

Rhoda: Yes, Mother. I gave him fifty cents and he let me wear the medal.

Christine: Then why didn't you tell this to Miss Fern when she questioned you?

Rhoda: Oh, Mommy, Mommy! Miss Fern doesn't like me at all! I was afraid she'd think bad things about me if I told her I had the medal!

Christine: Rhoda, you knew how much Claude's mother wanted the medal didn't you?

Rhoda: Yes, mother, I guess I did.

Christine: Then why didn't you give it to her? She is heart-broken over Claude's death. It's destroyed her. I don't think she'll ever recover from it. Do you know what I mean? No. You don't know what I mean.

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Rhoda: But it was silly to want to bury the medal pinned on Claude's coat Claude was dead. He wouldn't know whether he had the medal pinned on him or not. I've got the sweetest mother. I tell everybody I've got the sweetest mothering the world!—If she wants a little boy that bad, why doesn't she take one out of the Orphans' Home.

Christine: Rhoda! Get away from me! Don't talk to me. We have nothing to say to each other. When we lived in Baltimore, there was an old lady upstairs, Mrs. Clara Post, who liked you very much. You used to go up to see her every afternoon. She was very old, and liked to show you all her treasures. The one you admired most was a crystal ball, in which opals floated. The old lady promised this treasure to you when she died. One afternoon when the daughter was out shopping at the super-market, and you were alone with the old lady, she somehow managed to fall down the spiral backstairs and break her neck. You said she heard a kitten mewing outside and went to see about it and somehow missed her footing and fell five flights to the courtyard below.

Rhoda: Yes, it's true.

Christine: Then you asked the daughter for the crystal ball. She gave it to you, and it's still hanging at the head of your bed. Rhoda, did you have anything to do, anything at all, no matter how little it was, with Claude getting drowned. Look me in the eyes and tell me. I must know.

Rhoda: No, Mother. I didn't.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD

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